



Most Tor nodes aren't as sophisticated as the data centre pictured above

Simply looking for anonymizing tools like Tor will add you to an Internet watch-list, putting a greater spotlight on your activities (check out X-Keyscore, if you haven't already heard off it). Tempted as some of you might be, be warned, if you even attempt to perform any sort of illegal activity online, there is a high enough chance that you will be caught. The more illegal your attempt, the higher the chance.



Understanding Exit Nodes

When you connect to the Internet via Tor, your query is routed through the Tor network, but it also has to emerge from the Tor network to ultimately query the site you wanted. The point of exit is called an Exit Node and anybody can host one. Unfortunately, it's at these exit nodes that your privacy is at its most vulnerable because any data that passes through an exit node can be snooped on.

While all traffic in Tor relays is anonymous because it's quite literally encrypted and randomized, it's more cohesive at the exit node and snoopers know it.

Given Tor's structure and the fact that anyone can contribute their PC and its resources to the network, snoopers can also participate and setup their own exit nodes and relays, undermining the very thing that Tor stands for. Of course, the greater the number of exit nodes, the harder it'll be for snoopers to hijack data, which is why it's in



everyone's best interest to actually setup an exit node and relay yourself. This however, comes with a very big disclaimer (as you can see below).



Staying out of trouble

If you're running a Tor relay, you're relatively safe because it's almost impossible to figure out what's happening there. However, if you're hosting an exit relay, it's your IP that'll be traced back when authorities try to trace illegal activities to

a source. You're not responsible for the illegal traffic that passes through your network, since your device is a router of sorts, but until you can prove otherwise, you're likely to be in a tonne of trouble. This is an even bigger problem when you're in a country where the law enforcement agency even struggles to understand the difference between a PC and a monitor. Run an exit node with extreme caution and a full understanding of what you're letting yourself in for and the legal ramifications of your actions.

Suppose you do get into trouble, what then? Well, Tor will try to help you out, but don't count on it. The help they can provide will be more relevant to US law than Indian law so again, host with caution.

If you understand fully what you're doing, know that Tor is not illegal to run anywhere in the world. If you're accused of illegal activity for running a Tor Relay or node, here's a sample letter (<http://dgit.in/15JMqZ2>) that Tor prepared in response to DMCA notices. While the letter refers to U.S. Law, it'll give

you an idea of the kind of legal defense to aim for.



Accessing Hidden Services

To understand Tor's Hidden Services, you need to understand that Tor is like an Internet unto itself, like an office or college LAN network that's only accessible to those who're working or studying in said office or college, as applicable. Suppose you want to host a secure website and remain anonymous, you can't do that on the Internet. Also, Tor's security is weakest at the exit nodes. But what if you never had to exit the Tor network? What if all the data and information that you could want stayed within Tor?

Think of this as the deep web, an Internet within the Internet. A Hidden Service is effectively a web server (or any other type of server) that's running within the Tor network itself, maintaining complete anonymity for users and hosts alike. You can identify such services by the .onion web extension and as with TorChat, a Hidden Services web address will include the public key.

An in-depth explanation of the Hidden Services, including a list of publicly available services, can be found at <http://dgit.in/1xX51I5/>. You'll need access to the Tor network to access that site though.

How do you find other Hidden Services? By accessing Tor's own network search engine at <http://dgit.in/1yUeZaV>

Disclaimer: The deep web really is a dark and dangerous place and can be as bad, or worse, than your wildest imagination. It's a place that's haunted by pedophiles, drug peddlers, terror and other such ne'er do wells. This is not a place for children and even adults must approach the Deep Web with caution. Tor is a tool for anonymity, not illegal activity.